MinneMUDAC 2026 -- Team Roadmap

Sept 19 -> Oct 17, 2026

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4 weeks from kickoff to competition day at St. Catherine University. Graduate Division -- 6 questions to answer: **Q1, Q4, Q5, Q6 (+grad addendum), Q7 (+grad addendum), Q8.**

Built on: Challenge Brief, Data Question SlideDeck, the 5 Food Group data files, and the Rules of Engagement doc.

Before anything else (this weekend)

- ☐ **Request Feeding America Map the Meal Gap access.** This is manually approved and blocks Q1 + Q6 -- two of your six questions. Longest lead time in the whole project; start it before assigning any other task.
- ☐ Confirm the actual competing roster (rules cap teams at **5 students + 1 advisor** -- if more than 5 are on the group thread, settle who's competing vs. supporting before dividing work).
- ☐ Assign four rough workstream owners (people can hold more than one):
  - **Data/pipeline lead** -- cleaning, joins, the master county-month table
  - **Public-data lead** -- sourcing and documenting external datasets (SNAP, prices, Census, LILA)
  - **Modeling/analysis lead** -- the actual Q1-Q8 analytical work
  - **Narrative/deck lead** -- owns turning results into the 5-7 min pitch, keeps everything explainable
- ☐ Read the Glossary of Terms + Data Dictionary as a team (30 min sync) -- the dictionary's "Usage" column flags every deprecated field across all four tables, including `UniqueVisitsReg` at 0.1% populated. Decide as a team: **`HouseholdsReg` stands in for "Visits."** Write the decision down -- a judge will ask why.
- ☐ Email minnemudac@minneanalytics.org for the judging rubric (Allyson said it'd be on a shared drive -- chase it if it hasn't shown up).

Week 1 -- Sept 19-25: Foundation

Goal: clean, joined data + Q1 (the mandatory baseline) drafted.

- Standardize county names across `org_FSStats`, `Organization`, and `Incoming_Call` (118 raw variants in Incoming_Call alone -- typos, "County" suffixes, case differences, out-of-state).
- Build one **county-month master table**: aggregate `org_FSStats` (Households/Individuals/PoundsReg) by county-month, join cleaned `Incoming_Call` counts and `marketbucksUsage` on the same grain. This table underpins Q1, Q4, Q5, Q6.
- Join `Organization.block_geoid` to Census/ACS geography -- no separate geocoding needed, it's pre-derived.

- Pull Map the Meal Gap data as soon as access is granted; join to the master table by county.
- **Draft Q1**: correlate Feeding America estimates against the three food shelf metrics (using `HouseholdsReg` for Visits), identify counties where correlation breaks down, start pulling county characteristics (poverty rate, rural share, SNAP enrollment) to explain the mismatches.
- Source and document your first 2-3 public datasets using the brief's required 4-field format (publisher/series, geographic grain, time grain, why this source).

Checkpoint (end of week): Q1 has a first-pass answer, even if rough. If Map the Meal Gap access hasn't come through yet, this is the point to escalate -- you're already 1 week into 4.

Week 2 -- Sept 26-Oct 2: Core build-out

Goal: Q4, Q5, and the Q6 divergence metric all have working first drafts.

- **Q4** (food prices vs. food shelf activity): pull a food/grocery price series (BLS CPI is the obvious candidate), test for lag/delay in response, check all three metrics, not just one.
- **Q5** (SNAP enrollment vs. food shelf use): find a public SNAP enrollment source joinable to your county-month table; state its grain and publication lag explicitly (the brief requires this).
- **Q6** (divergence measure): this is your most creative question -- design a "need" metric that's more than just demand (e.g., blends poverty rate, SNAP participation, distance-to-food-shelf, and the Feeding America estimate). Start the **graduate addendum** now, not later: state a falsifiable definition of need, why it captures need rather than demand, and what evidence would make you reject or revise it.
- Keep documenting every public source as you add it -- don't let this pile up for later.
- Mid-week team sync: does the Q1 story (where/why need and demand diverge) actually connect to Q4/Q5/Q6, or are they four disconnected analyses? Judges will ask "what does The Food Group do differently on Monday" -- the throughline matters more than any single chart.

Checkpoint (end of week): four of six questions have working analysis. Flag anything still blocked (data access, a source you can't find) -- you have 2 weeks left to solve it, not more.

Week 3 -- Oct 3-9: Forecast, LILA, and stress-testing

Goal: Q7 and Q8 done; everything else gets challenged and tightened.

- **Q7** (forecast August activity -- visits/pounds/individuals, by MN county): use only data through July. **Do not look for or use actual August figures from any source -- this is a hard disqualification rule, not a guideline.** Build the **graduate addendum**: separate forecasts for children, seniors, and adults served.
- **Q8** (LILA areas & network reach): find your USDA-defined low-income/low-access tract source (state its definition and data vintage), overlay against `Organization` site locations via `block_geoid`, assess whether the food shelf network fills the retail gap or mirrors it. Explicitly discuss limitations -- the brief asks for this directly.
- **Team pressure-test session**: have someone who hasn't been in

the weeds play judge and ask each presenter "where did this number come from," "why this source and not another," "what would change your answer." Anything nobody can answer cleanly gets simplified or cut -- remember, explainable beats complex in this competition's judging.
- Reconcile all documented public sources into one clean source list/appendix.
- Start drafting the actual pitch narrative -- not slides yet, just the spoken argument, question by question.

Checkpoint (end of week): all 6 questions have a defensible answer + every team member can explain any of them cold. 1 week of runway left before showtime.

Week 4 -- Oct 10-16: Package, rehearse, tighten

Goal: presentation-ready, every team member fluent, logistics handled.

- Build the actual deck/materials for the 5-7 min pitch. Confirm whether a written/slide deliverable is due in advance of presentation day (still an open item -- chase this if unconfirmed).
- **Every team member prepares to present** -- the rules require this, not just a designated speaker. Rotate who leads each question in practice runs.
- Full run-throughs, timed: you'll repeat this 5-7 min pitch to 4-6 different judging panels (~8-10 min per interaction including Q&A), so practice for repetition and interruption, not just one clean delivery.
- Remove anything that reads as complex-for-complexity's-sake; each result should tie to one of the four decisions (allocation, siting, policy argument, measuring results).
- Logistics check: photo ID for entry, business dress with **no school branding** anywhere (clothes, badges, slides), confirm accommodations if traveling, confirm registration time (8:15am reg, judging starts 9am).
- Final gut-check on the "Visits = HouseholdsReg" substitution and any other assumption -- make sure the answer to "why did you do it this way" is rehearsed, not improvised.

Checkpoint (end of week): dry run complete, every team member can present any question, logistics confirmed.

Sat, Oct 17 -- Competition day

- 8:15am registration, judging 9am-noon (first round), afternoon finals for top teams per division.
- 5-7 min pitch x 4-6 judging panels (business/tech/academic mix per panel).
- Expect interruptions/requests for more detail -- you won't get through everything, so know what to cut on the fly without losing the thread.

Standing risks to watch across all 4 weeks

1. **Feeding America access delay** -- the single biggest schedule risk; started Day 1 for a reason.
2. **The rubric** -- still not in hand as of this writing; get it before Week 3 so you're not guessing what's graded.
3. **Submission format** -- unconfirmed whether anything is due

before Oct 17 beyond the live pitch; confirm early.

4. **Scope creep on Q6** -- it's the most open-ended question; timebox it so it doesn't eat Week 3.